



Sandipan Chattopadhyay, CTO, Just Dial (second from left), with other winners at the Red Hat Awards

— first we wanted assurance about the stability of the vendor and we wanted a secure and high performance platform. With years of experience in open source technology, watching players come, go, merge and demerge, I knew Red Hat was here to stay. The Red Hat stack was also very malleable, allowing us to go to any point, script it off and yet have the stack up and running perfectly well. Lastly, the scalability, and system performance of RHEL was undisputable,” says Chattopadhyay.

Just Dial adopted Ubuntu with a twist for its 3,500 desktops. “We used the Ubuntu OS, but removed parts that a particular set of users didn’t need. For example, we have three to four departments, with each department having a dedicated task. Our CROs (Customer Relations Officers) need the Web browser to be effective and need an optimal network stack. This was done by giving the maximum amount of available RAM so that they could use the cache to the fullest. Alongside, we made the cache for each system specific to the user, and Ubuntu OS allowed us to do that,” says Chattopadhyay.

The company also uses WebHuddle, a conference tool. The cross-platform functionalities, simplicity and easy usage of WebHuddle caught the eye of those at Just Dial. “We were entering new markets and with people getting more tech savvy, we needed a conferencing tool. We wanted an open source one as I believe in freedom, irrespective of whether we do anything with it or not. If I get an idea, I shouldn’t be twiddling my thumbs wondering how to take it forward. WebHuddle provided me that freedom and flexibility. It was also very simple and easy to use, which made it our choice over other open source conferencing tools,” says Chattopadhyay.

Open source – the loyal partner

But did open source turn out to be a staunch supporter to Just Dial? “Open source has never let Just Dial down. Improved performance, flexibility, cost efficiencies, scalability, and perfect alignment with the firm’s ambitious growth aspirations made this a perfect partnership for Just Dial,” claims Chattopadhyay.

Greater scalability

The open source IT architecture helped Just Dial improve scalability. Since the time the firm started using the RHEL

platform and CLAMP stack, it has been able to scale operations by three times. “Three years back, our executives used to attend close to 80,000 calls per day. That figure has crossed 250,000, as of today. We have also been able to scale our IT infrastructure without any hiccups. We have grown from five servers to more than 200, and expect our server count to reach 350 by the year end,” says Chattopadhyay.

A fine performance

Open source technology helped Just Dial extract tremendous performance from search systems and applications. “The platform allowed us to try things that we had never attempted before, helping us refine our search logic. On the old system, we were hitting dead ends related to the network and scalability. Open source freed us from vendor lock-in, and enabled the organisation to choose hardware platforms that delivered flexibility and high performance,” says Chattopadhyay. The open source architecture seamlessly ran mission critical applications like search logic, and also helped Just Dial improve the performance of its search logic by adding C components. For example, the company used Sphinx (which is a full-text search engine written in code C that’s designed to integrate well with SQL databases) on its LAMP architecture. “When the volume of data increases tremendously, most databases slow down. That is where non-database queries and lexis geographic searches gain relevance. Thus, we adopted Sphinx, a standalone search engine, and its easy integration in LAMP stack gave our search logic a boost. With its built-in data source drivers that support the fetching of data either via direct connection to MySQL, or PostgreSQL, Sphinx helped us achieve fast, size-efficient and relevant full-text search functions,” says Chattopadhyay.

The cost advantage

The open architecture also gave Just Dial a huge cost advantage. “Open source lowered the IT cost burden for us. At that point, if we had chosen Microsoft, we would have bled paying the licensing fees for 4,000 desktops and 200 servers. Today, we only pay Red Hat’s subscription fee, a gold support fee to MySQL, which is chicken feed compared to the licence costs associated with any proprietary vendor. Annually, we have saved at least Rs 80-90 million so far,” says Chattopadhyay. The open source solutions also simplified management and reduced systems maintenance costs. “Even though the server count has increased by more than twenty times (20x), we manage the infrastructure with almost the same team size,” says Chattopadhyay.

Further, the combination of Dell Power Edge Servers and Dell desktops with Red Hat proved to be a pocket friendly deal. “The Dell servers fitted our specific requirements with no frills. This cut costs in terms of hardware specs. Since we had compiled Ubuntu only for specific tasks, we needed lower spec hardware to run it, compared to what was needed to run generic Ubuntu software. Dell allowed us to do that through its flexibility in the desktop and server segment,” says Chattopadhyay.